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Metal Matters

We expect copper price upside from September with medium-term bullish view intact.

CITI'S TAKE

We publish April and May data for our global copper end-use consumption tracker. Negative headline implied y/y copper end-use growth reflects the distortive base effect of the policy-led spike in reported China renewable additions in 2Q'25. Implied growth in global copper end-use elsewhere has been tepid, but headline manufacturing sentiment remains robust. We expect renewed price upside from September and see copper touching \$15k/t within a year even as copper tariff dynamics and gold market headwinds threaten to limit gains through the summer (July and August).

Our conviction in near-term copper price direction is limited. We think copper will struggle to rally through the summer in our base case that US copper tariff fears fade and if bearish gold-price momentum is sustained — Our call for copper upside through June failed to materialise as a hawkish Fed surprised us, despite reliance versus June's broader commodity price pullback (e.g. gold, oil, aluminium). However, fading fears of potential Section 232 US tariffs on copper cathode risk weighing on sentiment in the coming weeks (given President Trump's end-June review deadline has passed and assuming our base case of no tariff announcement holds).

That said, we see positive price catalysts re-emerging from September including a more dovish Fed, greater focus on tighter copper physical market dynamics in 2027, and the structural medium-term bullish backdrop (please see our [114-slide Copper Book 2026](#) published late-June). We see copper averaging \$14,500/t through 4Q'26 as risks skew in our view towards a more dovish Fed on easing inflation and a softer US labour market, the potential for an eventual US-Iran deal, lower real interest rates, and a generally more supportive backdrop for demand and growth expectations.

Global manufacturing PMIs implied further expansion in activity in June, supported by AI-related investment and defence spending, despite softer sequential readings in the US and Europe. Resilience in manufacturing activity and these metal-intensive demand segments likely continue to support copper demand, a tailwind that our global end-use consumption tracker may be understating given it does not currently track these segments directly. Productivity gains from AI investment also have the potential to support copper pricing by supporting growth and quelling above-target inflation.

Headline implied global copper end-use declined by ~10% y/y in May'26, an anomaly due to the reporting spike in China renewable installations in May'25 (when GCET rose 13.5% y/y). Stripping out these distortions, underlying end-use appears tepid but resilient, with implied end-use growing ~1% y/y. Policy driven front-loading of China solar and wind installation reporting peaked in May'25 heavily distorting growth on a y/y comparison this year. Relying solely on headline copper-end use thus overstates the weakness in copper demand. Adjusting for solar/wind distortions, implied global copper end-use has risen 1.4% YTD vs a decline of 2.1% YTD on an unadjusted basis.

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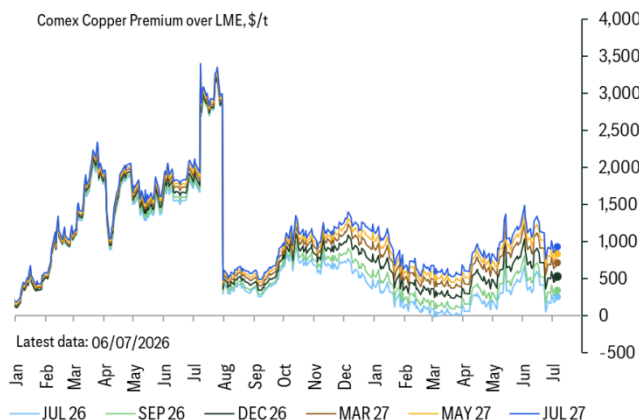
¹See Appendix A-1 for Analyst Certification, Important Disclosures and Research Analyst Affiliations.

Copper upside from September, medium-term bullish view intact

We expect renewed upside for copper prices after the summer as we look for prices to average \$14,500/t in 4Q'26 and to touch \$15k/t within a year. We think copper will struggle to rally sustainably through July and August given our expectation that the market will fade the tail risk of US import tariffs on cathodes over the coming months and given the potential for further bearish gold (and broader precious) price momentum near-term. By September, we see bullish catalysts re-emerging, including a more dovish Fed in response to softening US labour market conditions, a renewed focus on projected tighter physical copper market dynamics in 2027 and the structural copper bull case (see our 114-slide note published mid-June: [Copper Book 2026 – Structural tailwinds and cyclical sensitivity pave path to \\$15 k/t copper](#)). We think lower real interest rates, an eventual and more sustainable US-Iran deal and a more supportive backdrop for demand and growth expectations should further improve sentiment towards copper later in the year.

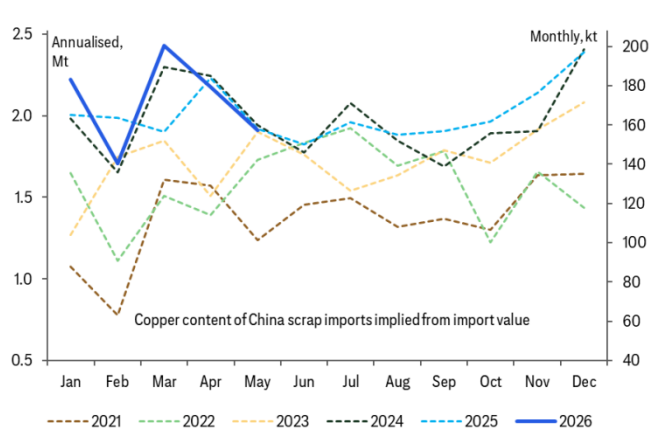
Our base case remains that copper cathode will not be subject to a Section 232 US import tariff. We think the market will be inclined to fade the tail-risk of tariffs through the summer since more than a week has passed since the June 30th review deadline without an announcement. The June 30th deadline set by President Trump last July for the review of Section 232 tariffs on copper cathode was over a week ago without any acknowledgement from the administration. Tariffs could still be announced in the coming weeks, but we don't think this is likely and we believe it is in the US administration's interest to maintain strategic ambiguity by neither implementing tariffs nor ruling them out. This can act as a headwind for copper pricing through July/August (more so for US copper prices given the current premium, Fig 1) if market participants opt to fade tariff tail risks although needs to be balanced against more bullish longer-term structural market themes and volatility in rates expectations around Fed comments and Strait of Hormuz developments.

Figure 1. We expect the COMEX premium over LME to ease further through July and August as tariff risk is faded (assuming our base case that no tariff is announced)



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Source: Citi Research, Bloomberg, CME Group, LME

Figure 2. China's copper-in-scrap imports close to flat y/y through to end-May suggested a muted global scrap response to much-higher copper prices.



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Source: Citi Research, TDM, China Customs, LME, Bloomberg

Broadly flat y/y China copper-in-scrap imports through May (Fig 2) despite much higher copper prices y/y imply a relatively price-inelastic scrap market.

Combined with flat mine supply anticipated in 2026, it suggests a very constrained supply-picture that can offset implied weakening of China demand growth this year. China's copper scrap imports were close to flat year-on-year through May, with April and May broadly in line with 2025 levels. Given the significantly higher copper price environment, the lack of a stronger import response suggests continued tightness in global scrap supply and a muted scrap availability response to price incentives. We see a balanced copper market in 2026 (Fig 3) swinging to a ~400kt deficit in 2027 basis current prices assuming a modest cyclical demand recovery, sustained energy transition and AI demand growth, versus around half-trend supply growth next year.

Figure 3. Citi copper supply and demand balance 2020-2030

kt Cu	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026f	2027f	2028f	2029f	2030f
Mine Production	20,752	21,179	21,808	22,395	23,128	23,398	23,334	23,739	24,509	25,272	25,880
% Change	0.7%	2.1%	3.0%	2.7%	3.3%	1.2%	-0.3%	1.7%	3.2%	3.1%	2.4%
Of Which Disr. Allowance (t)							973	1,805	1,926	1,964	2,023
Of Which Disr. Allowance (%)							4.0%	7.1%	7.3%	7.2%	7.2%
Refined Production	23,591	24,374	25,067	25,561	26,450	27,300	27,505	27,866	28,716	29,557	30,248
% Change	-0.3%	3.3%	2.8%	2.0%	3.5%	3.2%	0.8%	1.3%	3.0%	2.9%	2.3%
Refined Consumption	23,103	24,769	24,841	25,704	26,311	26,943	27,522	28,267	28,820	29,446	29,928
% Change	-3.4%	7.2%	0.3%	3.5%	2.4%	2.4%	2.2%	2.7%	2.0%	2.2%	1.6%
End-Use Consumption	24,165	25,908	25,984	26,886	27,521	28,182	28,788	29,567	30,146	30,800	31,305
Surplus/Deficit	489	-395	226	-143	139	357	-18	-401	-104	111	320
Av. Price (US\$/t ex-US)	6,183	9,318	8,830	8,485	9,145	9,950	13,700	14,250	14,000	14,000	14,000

*Updated 12-Jun-26, forecast production and consumption basis current ~\$13.5k/t spot price

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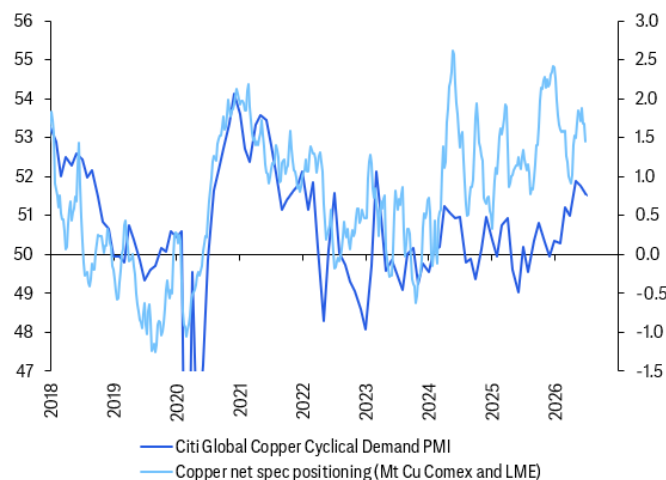
Source: Citi Research, Bloomberg, Wood Mackenzie, BGRIMM, IWCC, ICSG, Company Reports

Global factory output expanding even as near-term outlook clouded by more hawkish Fed and geopolitical uncertainty

Global June PMI prints suggest expanding manufacturing activity (see Figure 4 and 5) across all major economies including China, US and Europe. This is generally a supportive signal for cyclical copper consumption even as investor's increased pricing-in of Fed rate hikes has weighed on sentiment in recent weeks. China's manufacturing PMI has nudged back into expansion with the latest prints coming at 50.3. Export orders [continued](#) to lead the recovery, with high-tech manufacturing outperforming old-economy sectors. Our China economists expect further imminent targeted easing but not a policy pivot. The July Politburo meeting is the next catalyst to watch from a China policy perspective.

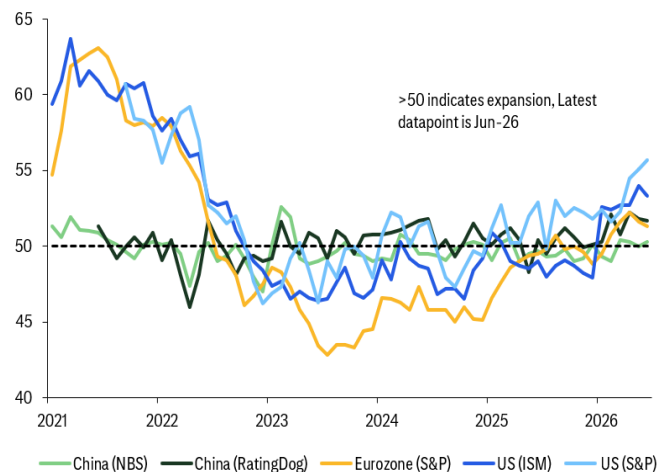
European PMI implied manufacturing expansion for a fifth consecutive month while US prints suggest modest growth in activity. Although June prints edged down slightly versus May for both Europe and the US, activity was supported by supply-chain disruptions linked to the Middle East conflict as consumers accumulated inventory ahead of feared price rises. The US manufacturing sector continues to show momentum as the buildout of AI infrastructure remains a tailwind. In addition, defence spending is emerging as a likely contributor to activity. Our US economists [expect](#) manufacturing PMIs to remain in expansion this year as these tailwinds persist.

Figure 4. Copper fund positioning remains net bullish amid structural demand drivers, supply constraint, and improving PMIs now also imply support.



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Source: Citi Research, Bloomberg, LME, CME Group

Figure 5. Global PMIs in expansion in recent months amid supply-chain stockpiling on Middle East tensions and AI/Datacentre buildout

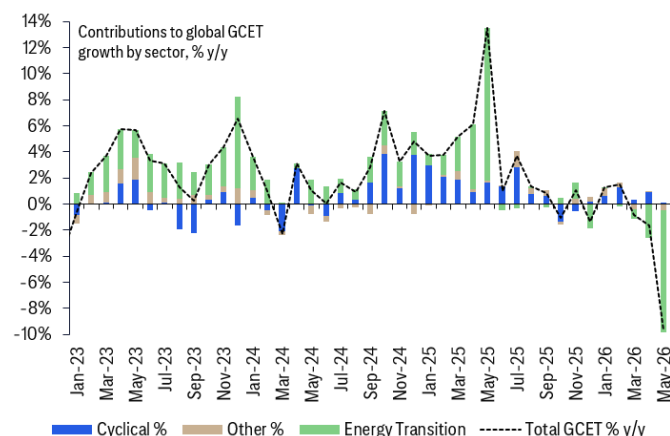


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Source: Citi Research, Rating Dog, Platts, Bloomberg, NBS, SMM

China's renewables base effect negatively distorting tracked global copper end-use, otherwise growing but sluggish

Implied global copper end-use from our proprietary GCET tracker declined by ~10% y/y in May 2026. This largely reflects a statistical base effect stemming from comparison against a record reporting spike in China's renewables installations in May 2026. Aggregate demand across all other segments rose +1% y/y. The weak headline print is not surprising and is consistent with our expectations in prior publications, where we highlighted the outsized impact of policy- and trade-driven shifts in China's renewable installations last year. Notably, May 2025 saw implied copper end-use growth of ~13% y/y, driven by exceptionally strong reported China solar installations, with energy transition-related demand surging ~120% y/y. More normalised reported installations through 2Q'26 look far weaker by comparison. China's renewables installation reporting is an imperfect proxy for underlying copper consumption given the policy-sensitive volatility which must be acknowledged when interpreting implied y/y growth rates from our tracker. The base effect is likely to reverse and drive more positive implied growth in 2H'26.

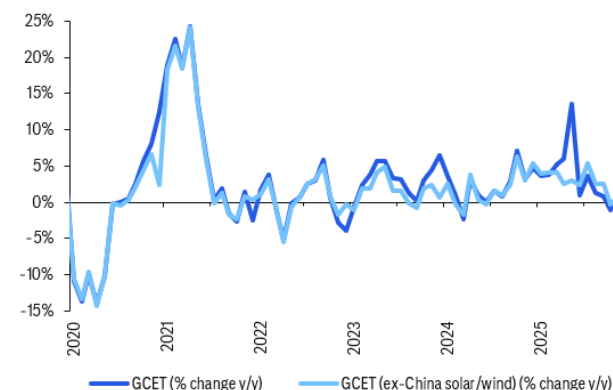
Figure 6. China renewable power installations weigh on tracked copper end use growth y/y amid strong base effect



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Source: Citi Research, ICA, Wood Mackenzie, Bloomberg

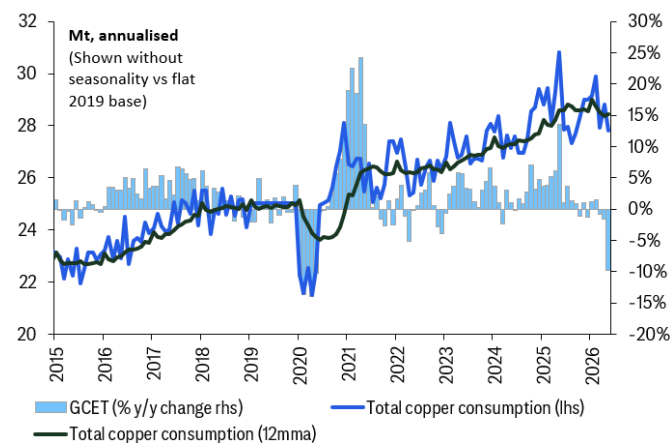
Figure 7. Global implied copper end-use grew ~1% y/y in May'26 after excluding consumption implied by China solar and wind reported capacity additions.



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Source: Citi Research, ICA, Wood Mackenzie, Bloomberg

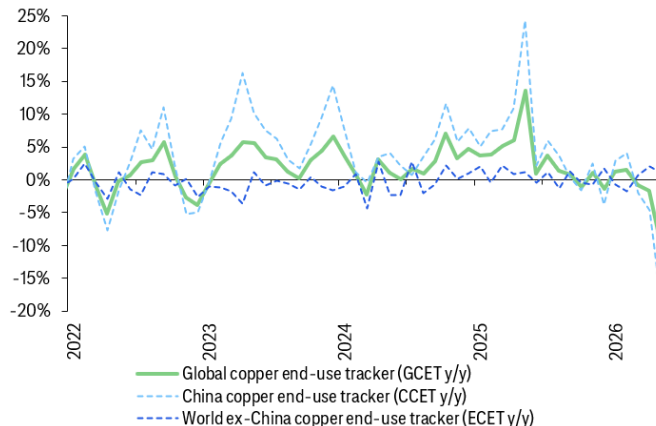
Figure 8. Total implied copper end-use (based on our tracker) annualizing at 27Mt



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Source: Citi Research

Figure 9. Weaker China implied copper end-use due to statistical effects weighs on global implied copper end-use



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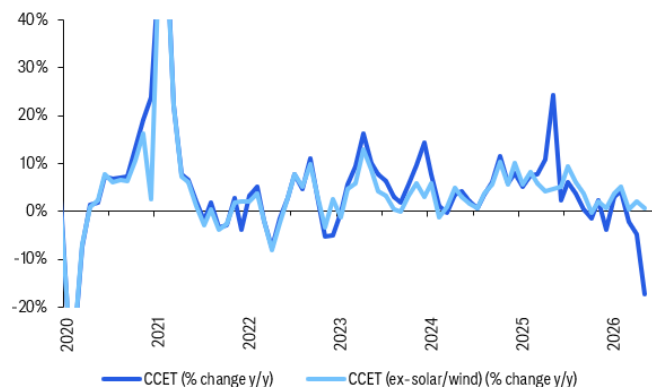
Source: Citi Research

China's weak headline copper end-use (as implied by our tracker) has been the primary drag on global consumption. China's copper end-use declined by ~17% y/y in May 2026. However, adjusting for distortions from the renewable sector, the underlying picture (see Figure 8) is more stable. Excluding solar and wind installations, China's copper end-use grew by ~0.6% y/y, indicating modest resilience in broader industrial demand. The key drag remains the sharp slowdown in renewable installations. China installed ~8.7GW of solar capacity in May—the lowest monthly run-rate this year—compared to an outsized ~93GW in May 2025. Similarly, wind installations came in at ~3.8GW versus ~26GW in the same period last year. This normalization following last year's front-loaded build-out has significantly reduced copper demand from the energy transition segment.

In addition, softer domestic EV demand has weighed on energy-transition-related copper consumption. EV wholesales are up just ~2% YTD, while retail sales have contracted ~15% y/y, pointing to weak domestic uptake. That said, this has

been partially offset by robust export demand, with EV exports surging ~115% y/y. Despite the sluggish start to EV sales in 2026, implied copper consumption from EVs still grew a solid ~17% y/y in May, supported by the export channel and ongoing electrification trends. Looking ahead, seasonality and policy support should provide a tailwind. We expect a stronger pickup in EV sales into 2H'26, underpinned by recently announced policy measures aimed at boosting EV consumption, particularly in rural areas.

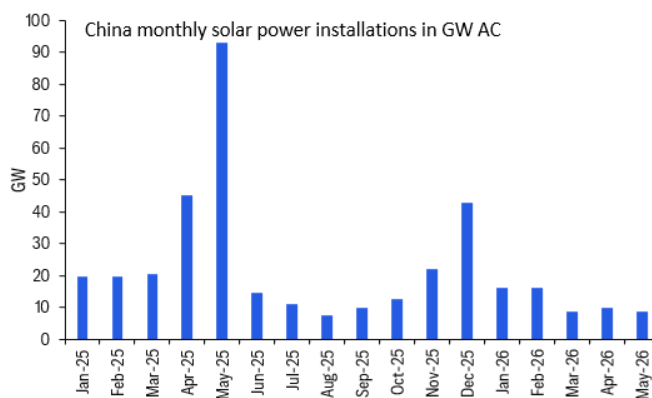
Figure 10. Excluding the impacts from solar and wind, China implied end-use grew ~0.6% y/y in May



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Source: Citi Research, ICA, Wood Mackenzie, Bloomberg

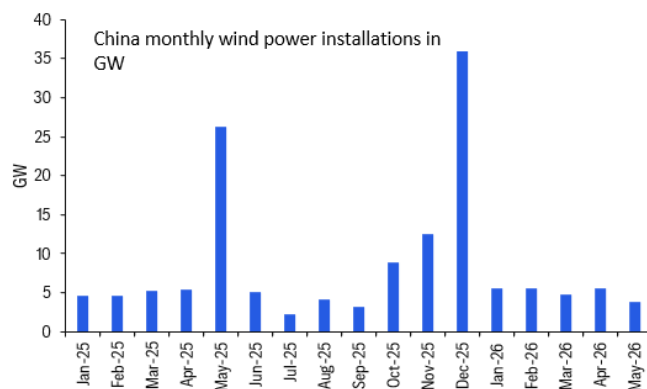
Figure 11. China reported solar installations down 70% YTD after spike in Q2'25



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Source: Citi Research, NEA

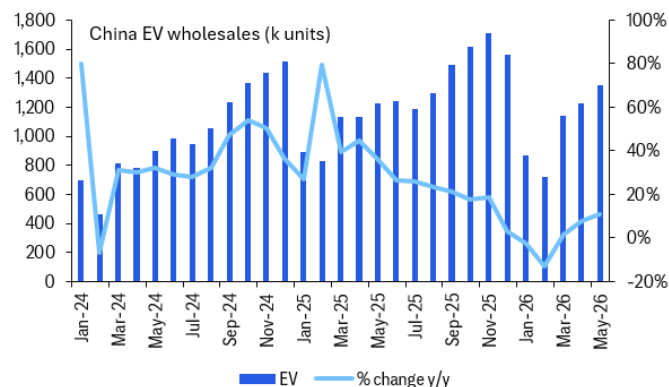
Figure 12. China reported wind installations down ~50% YTD against policy-led spike in May-25



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Source: Citi Research, NEA

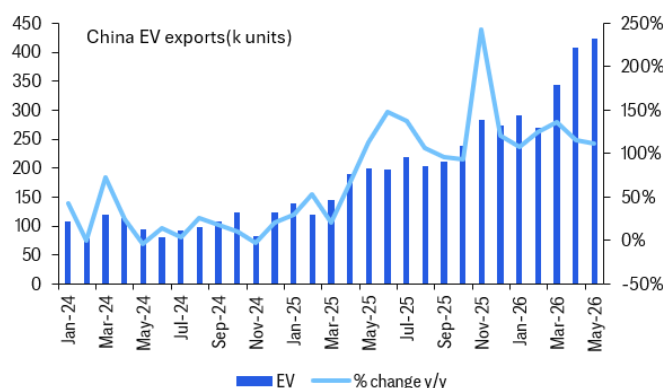
Figure 13. China EV wholesales +2% YTD



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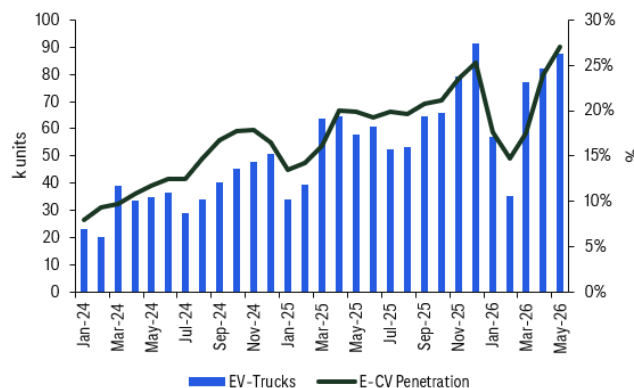
Source: Citi Research, CPCA, Bloomberg

Figure 14. EV exports the main driver of China wholesale autos growth



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Source: Citi Research, CPCA, Bloomberg

Figure 15. Electrification of commercial vehicles building momentum in China



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Source: Citi Research, CATARAC, Bloomberg

Implied ex-China copper end-use grew 1% y/y in May 2026 underpinned by a mix of energy transition and cyclical-related consumption. The outlook for ex-China remains a mixed bag near term. Demand-related concerns have emerged on a hawkish US Fed stance with investors pricing in rate hikes this year. Our house view in contrast [expects rate cuts from October](#). Rising AI-related capex is helping drive demand for power infrastructure equipment, including switchgears and transformers, thereby supporting copper consumption. In addition, continued growth in solar, wind and BESS installations outside of China is contributing to incremental demand. Manufacturing sentiment has been on an uptrend, with particularly strong PMI prints from the US which we may see reflected in some underlying tracked cyclical consumption series in the coming months.

Figure 16. Summary Table: Global, China, and World ex-China Copper Monthly End-Use Tracker (total demand including grid and power generation), implied % y/y change

	Apr-25	May-25	Jun-25	Jul-25	Aug-25	Sep-25	Oct-25	Nov-25	Dec-25	Jan-26	Feb-26	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26
Global Cu end-use tracker (GCET)	6.1%	13.5%	1.0%	3.7%	1.3%	0.8%	-1.1%	1.0%	-1.4%	1.3%	1.5%	-0.8%	-1.7%	-9.7%
Building and Construction	-3%	-4%	-3%	1%	-4%	-4%	-7%	-5%	-4%	0%	11%	-7%	-4%	-4%
Consumer appliances	-1%	0%	4%	4%	3%	-1%	-4%	-2%	-2%	0%	0%	4%	1%	0%
Machinery and Equipment	0%	0%	1%	1%	2%	2%	0%	1%	1%	0%	0%	0%	2%	1%
Automotive	15%	10%	7%	12%	11%	14%	7%	3%	0%	-3%	-9%	-2%	-2%	-1%
EV	40%	30%	21%	26%	24%	25%	18%	12%	5%	-3%	-12%	0%	5%	10%
ICE	2%	-1%	-1%	3%	2%	5%	0%	-5%	-4%	-3%	-7%	-3%	-6%	-8%
Power Grid (From Annual Est.)	3%	2%	2%	2%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%
Power Generation (Partly From Annual Est.)	69%	169%	-17%	-6%	-10%	-20%	-10%	16%	-11%	10%	11%	-18%	-31%	67%
Total Cyclical	1%	2%	2%	4%	1%	1%	-2%	-1%	0%	1%	2%	0%	1%	0%
Total Energy Transition	58%	118%	-4%	-3%	1%	-2%	4%	10%	-9%	1%	-1%	-6%	-20%	-49%
World ex-China Cu end-use tracker (ECET)	1%	1%	0%	1%	-1%	1%	-1%	-1%	2%	-1%	-2%	1%	2%	1%
Building and Construction	0%	1%	1%	2%	-2%	2%	-1%	-1%	2%	-2%	-4%	1%	2%	0%
Consumer appliances	-1%	0%	-4%	-2%	-5%	-4%	-4%	-3%	-2%	-4%	-2%	-3%	1%	-1%
Machinery and Equipment	0%	0%	0%	1%	0%	1%	0%	2%	2%	3%	1%	1%	3%	3%
Automotive	8%	3%	-3%	4%	2%	8%	1%	-6%	2%	-4%	-5%	-3%	-4%	-6%
EV	17%	8%	0%	9%	14%	22%	6%	-20%	-2%	-11%	-11%	-3%	-12%	-11%
ICE	6%	2%	-4%	2%	-1%	4%	0%	-2%	3%	-2%	-3%	-3%	-3%	-5%
Power Grid (From Annual Est.)	5%	4%	4%	5%	5%	6%	7%	8%	8%	9%	10%	10%	11%	12%
Power Generation (From Annual Est.)	2%	1%	1%	2%	3%	4%	6%	7%	8%	9%	10%	12%	13%	14%
China Cu end-use tracker (CCET)	11%	24%	2%	6%	4%	0%	-2%	2%	-4%	3%	4%	-2%	-5%	-17%
Building and Construction	-6%	-7%	-5%	1%	-6%	-8%	-12%	-9%	-7%	0%	20%	-12%	-9%	-10%
Consumer appliances	-2%	1%	6%	6%	4%	-1%	-6%	-4%	-3%	0%	0%	5%	1%	0%
Machinery and Equipment	-1%	-2%	2%	2%	10%	6%	0%	5%	1%	4%	4%	0%	7%	3%
Automotive	23%	19%	20%	22%	20%	20%	13%	10%	-2%	-2%	-14%	0%	1%	5%
EV	49%	39%	31%	33%	27%	26%	22%	23%	7%	1%	-13%	1%	10%	17%
ICE	-5%	-6%	5%	6%	8%	9%	-1%	-10%	-17%	-5%	-16%	-3%	-14%	-15%
Power Grid (From Annual Est.)	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	1%
Power Generation	170%	350%	-31%	-13%	-25%	-42%	-23%	23%	-16%	11%	12%	-46%	-56%	86%

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Appendix A-1

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